



LSO 100 — The Canadian Short Story

Week 14: Looking Back at the Canadian Short Story

Professor: Alireza Jafari

Welcome to Our Final Week

We have reached the final week of LSO 100: The Canadian Short Story. Across the semester, we have read stories from different periods, regions, communities, and cultural perspectives – moving from rural landscapes and family relationships to immigration, Indigenous identity, gender, memory, humour, and contemporary Canada.

This final week is about bringing those ideas together. Rather than introducing a new major reading, we will reflect on the stories we have studied, the literary skills we have developed, and the many ways Canadian short fiction represents identity, place, community, and change.

Which theme appeared most often?

Consider the recurring concerns across stories from different weeks.

Which story changed you most?

Which reading shifted your understanding of Canadian literature?

How has your reading changed?

Reflect on how your approach to short fiction has evolved since Week 1.

The Canadian Short Story: Where We Began

Early Themes

Our early readings introduced themes that recurred throughout the semester: survival, belonging, landscape, family, cultural difference, and memory. These ideas formed the foundation of the course.

Beyond Plot Summary

We began learning that literary analysis requires more than identifying what happens. We learned to examine how writers create meaning through characterization, setting, symbolism, imagery, point of view, dialogue, and structure. By now, "What happens?" should be only the beginning of your reading.

- Why does the writer tell the story in this particular way?
- What does the story suggest about its characters, community, or society?
- What details help us understand the larger meaning?



Landscape, Isolation, and Survival

Early in the semester, stories such as *"The Painted Door"* and *"To Set Our House in Order"* showed us that setting can do much more than identify where a story takes place. The physical environment can influence mood, conflict, relationships, and decision-making.

Physical Isolation

In *"The Painted Door,"* the storm literally surrounds the characters, cutting them off from the outside world and from each other.

Emotional Isolation

The storm does not simply surround the characters – it intensifies tensions already present within the marriage, making setting an internal force.

The Pull of Place

Throughout the semester, characters who left a place discovered that leaving does not mean leaving its emotional influence behind.

Family, Childhood, and Growing Up

With stories such as *"Boys and Girls"* and *"The Boat,"* we examined how family shapes identity. Children often begin by accepting the world around them as normal. As they grow older, they start to recognize unstated expectations involving gender, work, responsibility, tradition, and loyalty.

"Boys and Girls"

The narrator becomes increasingly aware that being a "girl" carries expectations she did not choose – expectations embedded in household routine, labour, and the language of those around her.

"The Boat"

Family tradition and personal ambition create a different kind of pressure – one where love, duty, identity, and independence do not always fit together. Growing up often means confronting these tensions directly.

- Both stories remind us that families communicate expectations even when they are never stated directly.

Small Towns, Rural Life, and Community

Our readings of *"The Lamp at Noon"* and *"Spit Delaney's Island"* continued our exploration of rural and small-town communities. Community can provide belonging and familiarity – but it can also create pressure, limit choices, and define what is possible for those who live within it.

Connection

Characters feel attached to a place because it represents family, history, identity, and livelihood. That attachment is real and meaningful.

Restriction

That same sense of place may limit choices, enforce conformity, or make leaving feel like betrayal – even when staying is painful.

Recurring Tension

The tension between connection and restriction is one of the defining concerns of Canadian literature, appearing across stories from very different regions and periods.

Urban Canada and Modern Life

When we moved into urban experiences through stories such as *"The Management of Grief"* and *"A North American Education,"* the course began to examine different forms of displacement and cultural complexity. Urban Canada introduces movement, diversity, migration, and encounters between people with different cultural backgrounds.



Private Grief, Public Systems

"The Management of Grief" shows how a deeply personal experience becomes entangled with public institutions and social expectations. Individuals and institutions may understand grief very differently.



Displacement and Belonging

Urban stories raise questions about what it means to belong when your background, language, or experience differs from those around you. Belonging in a city is rarely simple.



Immigration, Multiculturalism, and Belonging

"Simple Recipes" allowed us to examine cultural identity through family, food, language, memory, and generational difference. Immigration is not simply a movement from one location to another — it changes family relationships, traditions, and the way individuals understand where they belong.



Objects as Symbols

Food, recipes, and family rituals carry memories of another place and generation. Ordinary objects become charged with cultural meaning.



Language and Memory

Language is both a tool and a site of loss. Shifting between languages reflects shifting between identities and generational worlds.



Generational Difference

Traditions can become sources of disagreement when parents and children understand cultural belonging differently. Both perspectives hold real weight.

Indigenous Voices and Storytelling

With Thomas King's *"Borders"* and Eden Robinson's *"Traplines,"* we examined Indigenous identity, family, land, and colonial structures. These stories challenge us to think carefully about who defines identity, who has historically told stories, and how literature can resist dominant narratives.

"Borders" — Thomas King

The mother's repeated identification as Blackfoot — neither Canadian nor American — challenges the assumption that national identity must always fit within state-assigned categories. Her quiet refusal is both an act of resistance and a declaration of belonging on her own terms.

Why This Matters

Canadian literature contains many different histories and relationships to land. Studying Indigenous voices means asking: whose stories are told, and who has traditionally been allowed to define history?

- 📖 These stories remind us that literature can challenge the boundaries of nationality, identity, and belonging in powerful and lasting ways.

Language, Experimentation, and Narrative Form

As the semester continued, we became more attentive to *how* stories are constructed – not just what they are about. Literary form is not separate from content. The way a story is told contributes to what it means.

1

Point of View

Who tells the story – and what they can or cannot know – shapes everything the reader understands.

2

Chronology and Memory

Writers may move between past and present, disrupting linear time to reveal how memory shapes identity and meaning.

3

Withholding Information

Leaving important details unstated or revealed late can create tension, surprise, or dramatic irony – allowing readers to understand more than the narrator does.

4

Voice and Structure

The tone, rhythm, and organization of a narrative are deliberate choices that carry meaning far beyond mere style.

Gender, Relationships, and Identity

Through stories such as *"Boys and Girls"* and *"The Glass Bottle Trick,"* we examined how gender expectations shape identity and relationships. Gender roles may be reinforced by family, community, marriage, culture, and everyday behaviour – often so subtly that they can be difficult to recognize from within.

Reinforcement

Some characters internalize gender expectations gradually, absorbing them through routine, language, and the silent approval or disapproval of those they love.

Resistance

Others resist openly – through action, refusal, or choice. Even small acts of resistance carry significance within these narratives.

Power and Space

Control may appear through language, expectations, domestic space, or silence. A household setting can represent both belonging and confinement at once.



Memory, Loss, and Nostalgia

"The Closing Down of Summer" brought together themes of memory, work, family, place, and change. Throughout the semester, memory has helped characters understand – and sometimes misunderstand – their present lives.

Memory Is Not a Record

People remember selectively. They reinterpret the past, idealize certain experiences, and recognize painful ones differently as adults. Memory is shaped by the present as much as by the past itself.

What Remembering Reveals

In literary storytelling, the act of remembering can reveal as much about a character's present circumstances as it does about what actually happened. Nostalgia is never neutral – it is always shaped by desire, loss, and the need to make meaning.

- Why do characters return to particular memories?
- Can nostalgia make the past seem better than it was?
- How does remembering influence identity in the present?



Humour, Satire, and Canadian Identity

Our readings of *"One-Two-Three Little Indians"* and *"The Hockey Sweater"* demonstrated that humour can carry serious meaning. Humour is not separate from serious literature – it is a literary technique, and it deserves careful analysis.



Exposing Stereotypes

Humour can draw attention to stereotypes and social assumptions by making them visible in ways that a serious tone might not achieve as effectively.



Criticizing Institutions

Satire allows writers to criticize systems – cultural, political, linguistic – without stating that criticism directly. The reader does the interpretive work.



"The Hockey Sweater"

A childhood conflict over a hockey jersey becomes an exploration of language, community belonging, and the cultural politics of English and French Canada.

Future Directions and Contemporary Canada

In the later weeks of the semester, works such as *"How to Make a Friend," "Metalations of a Lake,"* and *"Pack Ice Season"* moved our attention toward contemporary Canada and the future. These stories reflect changing conversations about identity, race, belonging, technology, and environment.



1

Expanding Identity

Newer stories challenge older, narrower ideas about whose experiences count as Canadian.

2

New Concerns

Race, technology, environmental uncertainty, and community appear more urgently in contemporary fiction.

3

Literature in Motion

Canadian literature is not fixed. New writers continue to reshape what Canadian stories look like and whose voices are centred.

What Close Reading Means Now

One of the most important skills developed throughout this course is close reading – the practice of noticing details and asking why they matter. A strong literary response does not simply say, "This story is about identity." It explains *how* the story develops that idea, using specific evidence from the text.



A Repeated Image

What does the recurrence signal? What accumulates with each appearance?



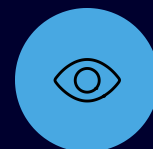
A Silence or Absence

What is not said can be as meaningful as what is. What is the story refusing to tell us?



A Shift in Tone

When the mood changes, something important has happened. Why there, and why then?



A Contradiction

When a character says one thing and does another, or when events resist easy interpretation, that tension is worth exploring.

Details become evidence.

Close reading is the practice of moving from observation to interpretation – from noticing a detail to explaining what it contributes to the story's larger meaning.

1

Identify the technique

Name what you see:
imagery, repetition, point
of view, dialogue,
structural choice.

2

Analyze its effect

Explain what the
technique does for the
reader, the character, or
the story's meaning.

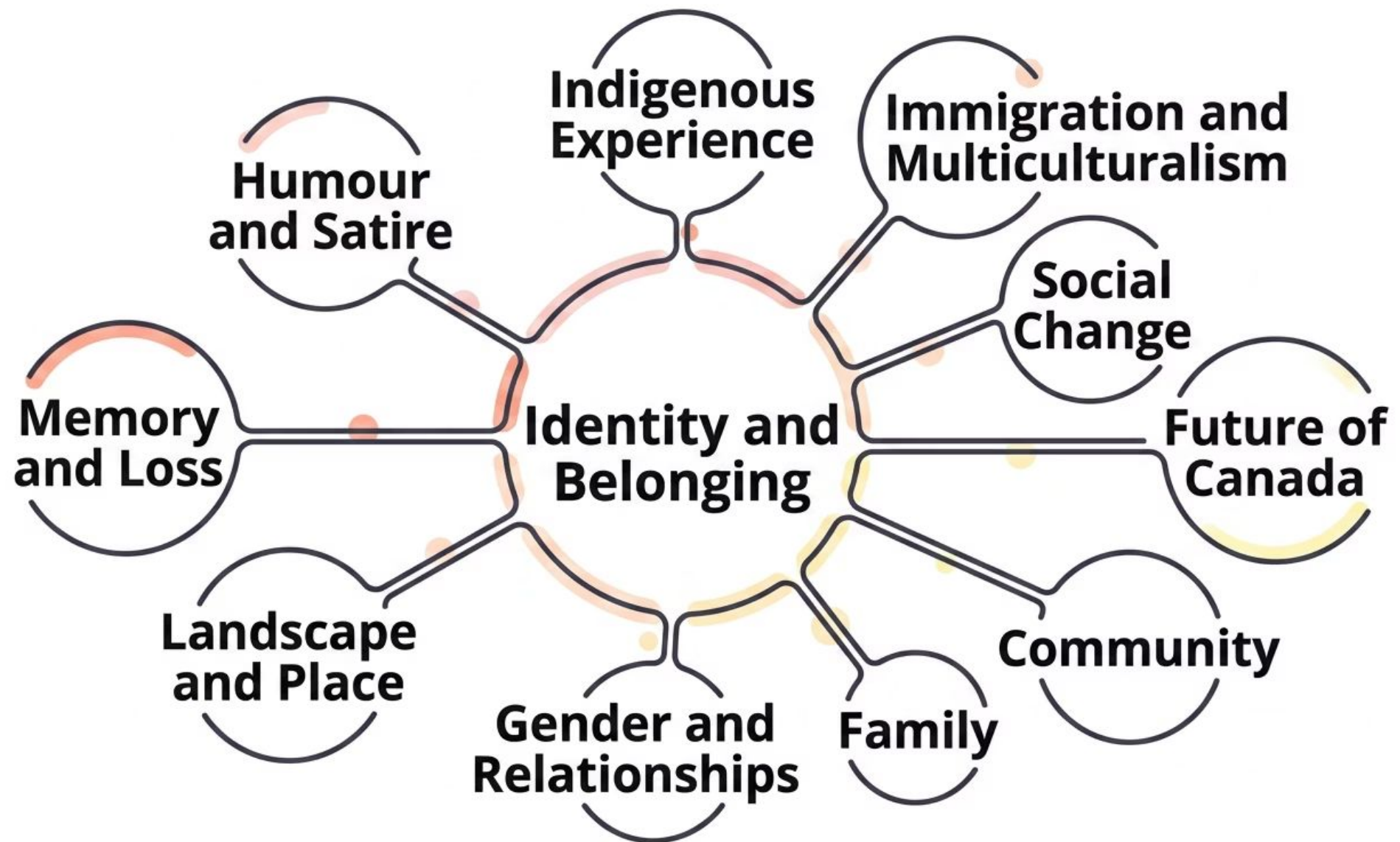
3

Connect to the whole

Show how this detail
relates to a larger theme,
pattern, or concern in the
work.

Bringing the Semester Together

When we look back across fourteen weeks, several themes have appeared repeatedly – yet the stories do not give us identical answers. That is important. Canadian literature is not one voice or one experience.



Reading these stories together allows us to see both connections and differences. The course has introduced us to different communities, regions, cultures, generations, and perspectives – each enriching our understanding of what Canada is and continues to become.

Recurring Themes Across the Course

Below is a summary of the major thematic threads that appeared across the semester. Each theme was explored through multiple stories and from different angles – rural and urban, historical and contemporary, individual and collective.

01

Landscape and Survival

Physical environment as a force shaping mood, conflict, and human behaviour.

02

Family and Identity

The way family shapes who we become – through love, expectation, tradition, and resistance.

03

Immigration and Belonging

The complexity of cultural identity across generations and languages.

04

Indigenous Experience

Challenges to colonial narratives and the assertion of cultural identity beyond national borders.

05

Memory and Change

How the past shapes the present and how literature uses remembering as a form of understanding.

Reflecting on Your Growth as a Reader

Think back to the beginning of the semester. Perhaps you once read short stories mainly for plot. Now, you should be more attentive to the deliberate choices writers make – and more comfortable supporting your interpretations with specific textual evidence.

Then: Reading for Plot

What happened? Who are the characters? How does it end? These are natural starting questions – but they are only the beginning of literary reading.

Now: Reading for Meaning

You now notice setting, symbolism, point of view, structure, tone, and language. You ask why the writer made particular choices, and you connect those choices to larger meaning. The goal is not to memorize every story. It is to become a reader who asks better questions.



Which analytical skill has improved the most for you this semester? Which part of literary analysis do you still find most challenging?

Preparing for the Final Assignment

The Final Assignment brings together the major skills and themes of LSO 100. As you prepare, focus on understanding rather than memorization. Return to important passages, review how literary techniques contribute to meaning, and think about connections between stories from different parts of the semester.

Close Reading

Identify specific details and explain what they contribute to the story's meaning. Evidence matters.

Character and Identity

Analyze how characters develop, resist, or are shaped by the forces around them.

Setting and Place

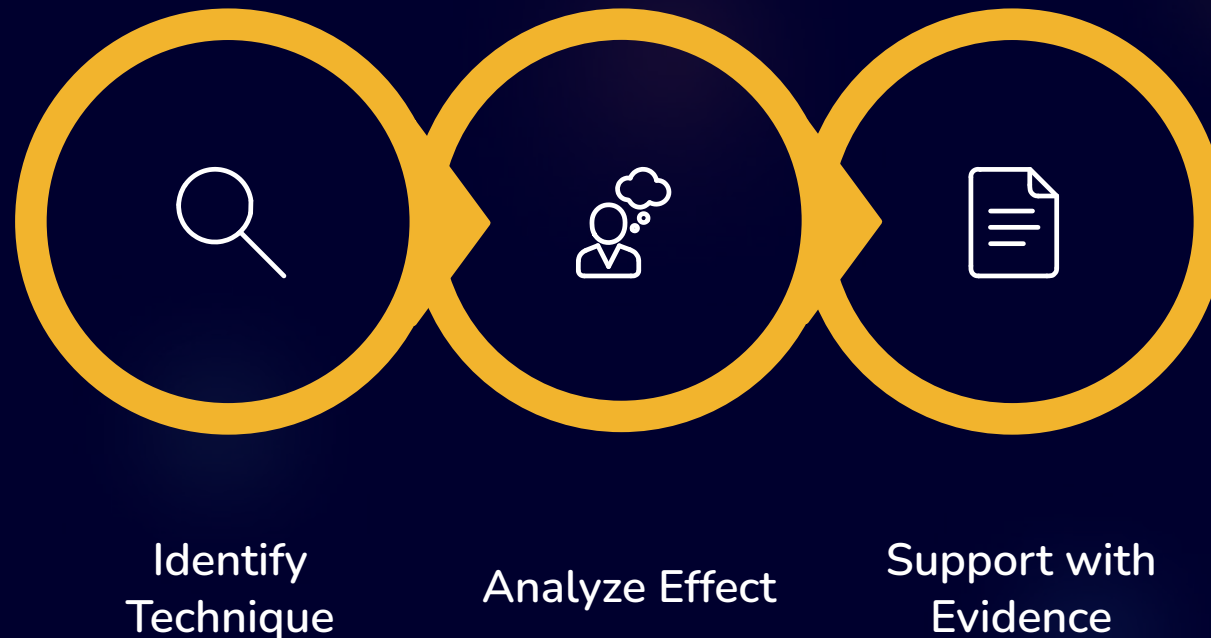
Examine how environment, community, and geography contribute to conflict and meaning.

Cross-Story Connections

Make connections between stories from different weeks to show thematic patterns across the course.

The most important question to ask yourself

Whenever you develop an interpretation, ask: **What specific evidence from the story supports this idea?** Analysis without evidence is only opinion. Evidence without analysis is only summary. Strong literary writing does both.



This three-step process applies to every literary response you write — from short answers to full essays. Practice it with each story you review before the final assignment.

What Does "Canadian" Mean Now?

We began the course by asking what the Canadian short story might tell us about Canada. Fourteen weeks later, the answer is more complicated – and more interesting – than it was in September.

Canada as Landscape

Prairies, coastlines, forests, storms – the physical world as a force in human lives.

Canada as Community

Small towns, urban neighbourhoods, families – belonging shaped by place and shared experience.

Canada as Memory

History, migration, loss, and the effort to understand where we come from.

Canada as Conversation

Indigenous voices, immigrant voices, rural and urban voices – literature as an ongoing dialogue.



Final Reflection: Many Voices, One Course

No single story represents Canada. Instead, Canadian literature becomes meaningful through the relationships among many different stories and voices. The course has shown us that identity – national, cultural, personal – is always constructed, always contested, and always in the process of being made.

“Has your understanding of Canadian identity changed through the stories we studied? Which voices or experiences expanded your understanding of Canada?”

“If you had to describe the Canadian short story in one sentence now, what would you say?”

These are not only questions about the course. They are questions about what literature can help us notice, understand, and reconsider – in Canada, and in our own lives.



Carrying This Forward

The skills you have developed in LSO 100 extend far beyond this course. Close reading, attention to evidence, awareness of perspective, and the ability to ask analytical questions are tools for understanding not only literature, but the world.



Read with Attention

Continue noticing how writers construct meaning through deliberate choices.



Ask Better Questions

Move past "What happened?" toward "Why does this matter, and how do I know?"



Listen to Many Voices

Seek out stories from communities and perspectives different from your own. Literature grows richer with every voice included.

References

The following sources informed the course readings, discussions, and frameworks used throughout LSO 100: The Canadian Short Story.

Bennett, A., & Royle, N. (2023). *An introduction to literature, criticism and theory* (6th ed.). Routledge.

Howells, C. A., & Kröller, E.-M. (Eds.). (2009). *The Cambridge history of Canadian literature*. Cambridge University Press.
<https://doi.org/10.1017/CHO.L9780521868761>

McCall, S., Reder, D., Gaertner, D., & L'Hirondelle Hill, G. (Eds.). (2017). *Read, listen, tell: Indigenous stories from Turtle Island*. Wilfrid Laurier University Press.

New, W. H. (2003). *A history of Canadian literature* (2nd ed.). McGill-Queen's University Press.

Sugars, C. (Ed.). (2016). *The Oxford handbook of Canadian literature*. Oxford University Press.
<https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199941865.001.0001>